MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM
MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR /IMPROVEMENT/ REAPPEARANCE EXAMINATION NOVEMBER 2025
FIRST SEMESTER
Multi-Disciplinary Courses (MDC) - MG1MDCFSQ102 - FOOD AND CULTURE

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 35**

Part A
Multiple Choice Questions
Answer All Questions
Each Question carries 1 mark

1. b) How people grow, cook, share, and think about food.

2. a) To signify abundance and prosperity

3. c) Food localization

4. a) Strength and sweetness in relationships

5. a) Roast Turkey

6. b) Kimchi

7. b) Promotes innovation and creativity

8. a) To seek blessings from the goddess

9. b) Prosperity and abundance

10. d) All of the above

11. b) Historical, social, and cultural influences on dietary practices.

12. a) They signify the arrival of spring and joy.

13. a) Replace pork with halal-certified chicken or beef

14. d) All of the above

15. d) All of the above

Part B

Short Essay Type Questions

*Answer any **4** Questions*

*Each Question carries **5** marks*

16. How do the choice and availability of ingredients impact the authenticity of a dish in different regions?

Ingredient availability plays a major role in determining how authentic a dish remains when prepared in different regions. Traditional dishes are deeply tied to local crops, climate, soil conditions, and cultural farming practices. When certain indigenous ingredients are not available, cooks often substitute them with locally accessible items, which may alter the original taste, flavour, aroma, and texture. For example, replacing Indian spices with milder ones in Western countries can reduce the authenticity of curries. Similarly, tropical ingredients like coconut, tamarind, or certain millets may have no exact substitutes, resulting in modified versions of the dish. While adaptation makes a dish suitable for local taste, authenticity may be compromised because the original sensory experience, cultural significance, and traditional methods rely heavily on the native ingredients..

17. How does the preparation of food during Vishu reflect Kerala's agricultural heritage?

Vishu celebrations strongly highlight Kerala's agricultural richness and seasonal abundance. The festival marks the beginning of the agricultural year, and the Vishukani includes freshly harvested produce such as rice, coconut, cucumber, jackfruit, mangoes, and vegetables—symbolizing prosperity. Vishusadhya dishes are prepared using seasonal ingredients, reflecting Kerala's dependence on its fertile soil and monsoon-driven farming. The use of fresh vegetables like ash gourd, pumpkin, and plantain signifies the diversity of Kerala's crops. Rice, which is a staple of Kerala agriculture, appears in multiple forms such as Vishu kanji and payasam. Thus, Vishu food traditions reinforce Kerala's strong agricultural identity and gratitude for natural abundance.

18. Write a brief note on globalization and food trade.

Globalization has significantly transformed food production, distribution, and consumption. Through global trade networks, ingredients that were once confined to specific geographical regions are now available worldwide. This enables the spread of culinary practices and fusion cuisines, contributing to cultural exchange. International food corporations, improved transportation, and cold-chain storage have expanded markets for spices, grains, fruits, and processed foods. However, globalization also leads to certain challenges: traditional food systems may weaken, local cuisines may become homogenized, and small farmers may face economic pressure. Despite this, global food trade has made diets more diverse, increased accessibility to exotic ingredients, and facilitated the exchange of culinary knowledge between cultures..

19. Illustrate how ancient civilizations like the Greeks or Romans shaped modern culinary traditions.

Ancient Greek and Roman civilizations made several contributions that continue to influence modern cooking. The Greeks developed early concepts of balanced diets, olive oil usage, and wine culture, which remain central to Mediterranean cuisine today. They introduced herbs like oregano, thyme, and basil, and emphasized the combination of grains, fruits, and vegetables in daily meals. Romans expanded these ideas and introduced innovations such as advanced bread-making techniques, preserved foods, sauces like garum (a precursor to modern fish sauces), and sophisticated banquet culture. Roman trade routes also helped spread spices, wheat, and olives across Europe. Many modern European dishes, including pasta variations, sauces, and baked goods, trace their origins to these civilizations.

20. What are some iconic Christmas dishes in different parts of the world?

Christmas celebrations worldwide feature unique dishes reflecting each region's culture and food habits. In the United States and the UK, roast turkey or roast beef with mashed potatoes and gravy is common. Germany is known for Stollen, a rich fruit cake dusted with sugar. In Italy, families enjoy dishes like Panettone and Feast of the Seven Fishes. Mexico celebrates with Tamales and Pozole, while the Philippines features Lechon (roast pig) and Bibingka (rice cake). In Australia, Christmas meals often include cold seafood like prawns because it falls in summer. These dishes highlight how Christmas food traditions vary globally, blending local ingredients with Christian festive customs.

21. What role does freshly harvested rice play in Pongal celebrations?

Freshly harvested rice is the centerpiece of Pongal celebrations, symbolizing abundance, prosperity, and gratitude for a successful harvest. The festival is dedicated to the Sun God, thanking him for agricultural prosperity. Using newly harvested rice signifies new beginnings and the hope of a fruitful year. The dish "Pongal," cooked in a new clay pot with fresh rice, milk, and jaggery, represents the overflowing of wealth and happiness. The first grains of the harvest are believed to bring blessings to the household. Thus, freshly harvested rice reflects both agricultural significance and deep cultural symbolism in Pongal traditions.